

Building a Powerful Linux System for Newbies

As the Free Software Foundation celebrated 30 years of activism, it asked each of its supporters to help someone they know dump Windows 10 and move to Linux. Towards that end, this article focuses on building a powerful Linux system that will suit most users and yet is easy to provide support for.

First impressions are the best. When building a Linux system for a Linux newbie, it is important that you go beyond the default installation. You need to add additional software, configure the system for the best combination of convenience and aesthetics, and provide the new user with simple tips and tricks to be self-sufficient.

Linux distributions

In this article, I would recommend Linux Mint. You could however choose whichever distribution you are comfortable with. As Mint is based on Ubuntu (which, in turn, is based on Debian), it uses the DEB package format, and thus benefits from the many software repositories with DEB packages. DEB packages also make it easy to install and uninstall Linux software programs.

When downloading the Mint OS ISO file, select the 64-bit version. The 32-bit version will not be a good choice as the OS would then be not able to access more than 3GB of the system RAM. Another thing to note before downloading the ISO file is the desktop manager. Mint comes in two flavours - Cinnamon and Mate.

The desktop

This article recommends Linux Mint with the Mate desktop. Mate is a fork of the GNOME 2 desktop manager. Like Windows 8, GNOME 3 seems to favour visual bling at the expense of features. It relies on extensions to provide settings and features that are considered basic in GNOME 2. In contrast, the Mate desktop offers all the usability and accessibility benefits of GNOME 2, and looks great with the Nimbus theme.

The Linux Mint Mate desktop uses a custom main menu. The original GNOME 2 style has been made optional and surprisingly described as a 'custom menu bar'. Go ahead and get rid of the 'Main Mate Menu', and add the old GNOME 2-style 'Menu Bar'.

The GNOME 2-style main menu is neatly organised - all software programs are available under *Applications*; all important storage locations (important home directories,

bookmarks, network locations, etc) and recent documents are under *Places*; and all settings and administrative tasks are under *System*.

From one corner on the desktop, it provides you with complete control over the entire system. Many new modern alternatives do not have this simplicity and force users to scramble all over the screen.

Other things that you might want to add to the panel would be:

- Workspace switcher
- Notification area
- Window list
- Show desktop

You might also want to add icons of important programs to the panel—that of the browser, email client, the Mate terminal and screenshot, and Pluma (the text editor).

All these simple enhancements will greatly improve the usability of the desktop and will prove extremely valuable when you are providing support over the phone or by email. As mentioned earlier, first impressions are the best. Default installations of Linux can look so drab or intimidating that many new users will simply revert to the familiar comfort of their old OS.

